NINE

Card 0144

NELL · DAY 23,236 · WEDNESDAY 27 MAY 2026

I'D POSTED THE letter at four that morning, with my surname blacked out and the link to the grey page underneath, because I'd promised myself I'd never be alone with something like that again.

By nine I had a hundred and forty emails. By ten, somebody calling himself Owlfancier had looked at the source of the page, which I hadn't known a page had, and found a note hidden there for anyone who cared to look. It was a few words and a number: *harlow-vane index. card 0144.*

The Harlow-Vane Institute for Systems Studies still had a website. It looked as if it had been built by a retired man out of loyalty, and it had last been updated in March 2017. There was a crest with a sundial on it, a list of papers nobody could have wanted, and a search box. You typed in a number. Nearly all the numbers gave you *This card has not yet been digitised.*

0144 gave you a yellow index card, front and back, typed and stamped and scribbled on across thirty-four years in four different inks. At the foot of the page, in small grey print, it said how many times it had been viewed since it was digitised.

When I first looked, the number was 1,306. I refreshed it. 1,341.

Crane, Hollis Raymond. Born 1945. He'd joined in 1973, in something called C.S.S. In 1979 somebody had made him *H.H. liaison*. In 1984 he'd delivered a thing called Model 7, and he'd been *commended*. In 1991, in a different pen, *reservations noted*. His department had an explanation on the back, in a hand that had pressed quite hard: *Carrying-capacity & Social Stability.* And the last annotation of all was his own, I thought, by the look of it: a small upright line, in pencil, from an old man to whoever came.

I am old and slow.

I knew *H.H.* I'd read it in a vehicle log with a ledger on my forearm. I sat and looked at those two letters and then I searched his name, and I found a withdrawn paper, a dissolved institute and an obituary for someone else. He was eighty-one, if he was alive. I started a letter to him. I started it four times.

1,902.

* * *

He wrote first.

It came on the Sunday, at two minutes past six in the morning, to the address my readers use to tell me I'm brave or mad. The subject line was the line from the card. I won't copy it all out. It was short and very courteous and he said *I* thirty-one times; I counted, of course, and I couldn't have told you why it made me feel better. He'd watched a number climb on a website he kept, he said, and at his age he hadn't expected a number to frighten him. He had done arithmetic for people he admired and later for people he feared, and he couldn't say when the one had become the other. He wouldn't tell me anything in a letter. I, of all people, would understand why. He'd meet me somewhere public, in daylight, somewhere with a timetable. I should bring someone.

Then, in the middle, by itself:

I knew of your father. Not well. I say it first because I think you would rather hear it from me than work it out.

And at the bottom, after the initials: *Please stop counting forwards. They count faster than you.*

I read it standing up. Then I rang Danny, who said old men had started most of the trouble he'd ever seen, and couldn't get a day off the app anyway. Then I walked down to the hall, and Ama listened to the whole thing, polishing her glasses on her cardigan.

"If he's lonely, he'll be glad of the company," she said. "If he's dangerous, he'll be less so with two of us looking at him." She put the glasses on. "Does he take sugar, do we know?"

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THURSDAY 4 JUNE

HE'D CHOSEN A junction town I'd only ever seen from a train: four platforms, a footbridge, a café on Platform 2 with steamed-up windows and a board that clicked over with the departures. We got there an hour early. Ama took the table next to the one by the radiator, with her back half turned and a library book she didn't open, and I understood how that looks from the other side.

I didn't see his train come in. A very tall, very thin old man was walking towards the door with a stick he plainly didn't need, in a good overcoat that had been bought for someone bigger, and he stopped to let a boy with a bicycle go first and thanked him for it.

"Ms Okafor-Reyes," he said, at the table. He'd taken his hat off. He looked at Ama's back, and he bowed very slightly to it. "And you've brought someone. I'm so glad. May I?"

I'd spent days preparing to dislike him.

He had a beautiful voice, dry and light, and a way of finishing a long sentence with a short one. He asked if the train had been on time, and he told me what time it had been due, and the number of the unit. He said the tea here had been dreadful since 1974 and that he'd come to depend on it. He looked at my notebook and asked if I ruled my own columns, and when I said I did he nodded as if that

settled something.

"What was C.S.S. counting?" I said.

"Ah," he said. "No preamble. Good." He turned his cup a little in its saucer. "You were a freight analyst. Tell me what *carrying capacity* means."

"It's what a vehicle can carry. Payload."

"So it is. That's where it began. Some time in the 1840s, in the shipping returns. It was a number stamped on a hull: this vessel will carry so many tons of cargo and no more. A sound, honest, useful number. I've seen it on bills of lading you've probably handled." He smiled at me. "And then, some way into the following century, a gentleman in the American West who was concerned about overgrazing borrowed it for a pasture. Such-and-such a range will carry so many head of cattle. You see how natural that is. And then the ecologists had it, for deer. You can look all of that up, and I hope you will."

The board clicked over behind him. Nobody on the platform looked up.

"And then?"

"And then it was 1973, and I was twenty-eight, and I was given a very nice office," said Hollis Crane. "I don't think anyone ever decided. A word just moves along a shelf. One morning you find you are using it about a town."

I wrote that down. My hand was perfectly steady. It was the most frightening thing anyone had said to me all year, and he'd said it like someone remembering a good holiday.

For an hour he told me things. I'd had pieces of it for months, from a hundred bad websites and my own nerves. He had it in order. He told me how a dull little institute had got its money, and how a man might be promoted for years without once being told what his tables were for. He remembered dates to the day and prices to the penny. He knew what a tonne of freight had cost to move from the docks to the Midlands in 1978. Now and then a line of a hymn came up in his talk, and he stopped and looked at it with

mild distaste, like a man finding an old photograph of himself in uniform.

"*Time, like an ever-rolling stream.* I don't believe a word of it, you know. I only wish it would leave."

"What's H.H.?"

"You know what H.H. is."

"Who was T.?"

He looked at me for rather a long time. The radiator ticked, and at the next table, Ama turned a page she hadn't read.

"I'm not going to answer that today," he said. "That isn't coyness. If I tell you in a café, you'll think I'm a mad old man, and you'll be quite right to, and then you'll stop checking. I would so much rather you went on checking. So." He laid two long fingers on the table, on the Formica, as though on a page. "I shall give you one thing, and you needn't believe it. Go and look. The Ashby Trust wound up in 2011, and it had to file its last accounts, like any other body. Anyone may read them. Nobody ever has. Note nine, I think."

"What's in note nine?"

"Oh, nothing at all," said Crane. "That's what's so interesting about it."

I asked him about my father then. I'd told myself I wouldn't.

His face didn't change. I was watching for it. But he took a moment to get his cup exactly into the ring it had left, and he did it with such care that I felt, ridiculously, sorry for the cup.

"He kept very good records," he said. "I only ever saw them. I'd know that hand anywhere, as one knows a good bridge. Is that any use to you? It's not much. I told you it wouldn't be." He looked up at the board, and he reached for his hat. "I'm the 16:12, and you'll want the 16:42. The 16:20 looks better, but it stops everywhere, and you've had a long day."

He stood, in sections. He bowed again towards Ama's back, and she turned at last and looked him up and down over her glasses, for about as long as you'd look at someone asking to come

in out of the rain.

"Dr Crane," she said. "Do you sleep?"

"No, madam," he said, and he seemed delighted to be asked. "Not since 1987."

I watched him go along the platform, not hurrying, with his stick under his arm now. I liked him. I may as well say so. I'd been lied to by every screen I owned for a year, and here was somebody who told me to check.

It wasn't until he'd reached the footbridge that I thought: I never said which way I was going.

But then he'd know. Half the internet knew my road. He'd have looked up the trains, because that's what he was: a man who read timetables for pleasure and had a nice manner and couldn't stop. I'd have done the same. I drank the last of the dreadful tea and let it go.

"Well?" I said to Ama.

"He's frightened," she said. "I don't know of what." She shut her book. "I don't think he does take sugar."

I found it on the platform, on my phone, with half an hour to wait. It took me most of that to get past the registry's front page and pay it three pounds. The final accounts of the Ashby Trust ran to fourteen pages of perfect dullness, and I've read a great many of those, and I felt myself come up to it the way you'd come up to a dog you've been told is fine.

Note nine was a line and a half. *Plant and equipment.* The Trust held one item of plant in store at a bonded warehouse, carried in its books at nil value.

One item. Worth nothing. I nearly laughed. I scrolled on down, for the sake of being thorough, to the note on insurance, which nobody ever reads, and which I've been reading for eleven years.

It had been the largest single cost in the Trust's accounts. For a warehouse with nothing in it worth a penny, somebody had paid the premium in full, every year. The note gave the date the cover began, in the dull little voice of a note. *Continuous from March*

1971. And in the last line, *transferred with the asset*.

The 16:20 came in, stopping everywhere, and went out again. I stood on the platform with the wind going through my coat, and I'd stopped being cold. I'd found the manifest of a machine going out of that house, no weight, no charge. And for forty years at least, through every year my father went to work, somebody had been keeping it dry.

It was still somewhere. He had told me that, and it was true. I had checked.

* * *

HOLLIS CRANE · THE 16:12, THE SAME AFTERNOON

HE HAD A table to himself, facing backwards, which he preferred. It was better to see where one has been.

The telephone was a small plain one they had given him last week. He let the train clear the points and settle down to its speed before he took it out. It answered on the first ring, as it always did, and a pleasant voice, a young voice, the voice of somebody who'd been to a good school and had a good lunch, said, "Dr Crane. How was your tea?"

"Dreadful, thank you."

He told it everything. He had always been good at this. He gave it in order, with the times: that she'd come an hour early, that she ruled her own columns, what she'd asked and in what sequence, and which of those questions had surprised him. He described the pastor and the library book. She had asked about T., and he had not replied. She had asked about her father, and he told the voice exactly what he'd said to her, word for word, including the bridge.

"And she liked you?"

He looked out of the window. The junction had gone, and there was a field going by, and then another, in long clean rows. Somebody had been at it with a drill.

"Yes," he said. "I believe she did."

"Lovely. And the note?"

"She'll have found it by now. She's her father's daughter."

"The family will be so pleased," the voice said. "Do look after yourself, Doctor. It's a filthy evening down your way, I understand."

He put the telephone away in his overcoat. His cup had been a good one, in its way; she had seen him settle it. He took a cheap ruled notebook out of his other pocket, and uncapped his pen, and looked for a while at a clean page.

Time, like an ever-rolling stream.

He wrote down the date. Under that, after some thought, he wrote: *She counted the I's.* He had seen it in her face before she had said a word. He'd written the thing that way on purpose, and it had taken him most of a night.

He looked at that, and he went on looking at it until the light was gone from the rows.